strange that the Pali chronicles do not write of her playing a pivotal role in Ashoka's conversion. Possibly, a male protagonist as the crucial character in making him a Buddhist was more in line with the thinking of the times. Ashoka's importance in converting the Sri Lankan king Devanampiya Tissa is matched by that of his son Mahinda who carried, in a manner of speaking, the Buddhist faith to Sri Lanka. Women in such narratives, and not just in India, are mostly the 'helpmeets' of dominant males.

Coming back to the emperor's quest, the most elaborate telling of the story occurs in the *Dipavamsa*. The search began shortly after he became ruler, this being mentioned in a matter of fact way in relation to his son Mahinda, a crucial figure for the Sri Lankan tradition because of his mission to establish Buddhism there. The text notes that Mahinda was 10 years old when 'his father put his brothers to death', and he was 'anointed king in Mahinda's fourteenth year'. For three years Ashoka is said to have honoured people who are described as 'Pasandas'. This is likely to be an umbrella term for a variety of religious orders since many are mentioned in the narrative—Pasandas who proceeded from the Sassata and Uccheda doctrines, Niganthas, Acelakas, Brahmans, Titthiyas, other ascetics, and sectarians.[6] They were invited to the palace, and great gifts were bestowed on them in the hope that they could answer a question the king posed to them. Disappointingly, none of them could answer his question. What this question was the text passes over in silence, but it was apparently 'an exceedingly difficult question'. In this way the Pasandas were 'annihilated' and the sectarians 'defeated'.

The search ended when Ashoka came upon a Buddhist Bhikshu called Nigrodha looking for alms on a Pataliputra road, 'a handsome young man of tranquil appearance, who walks along the road like an elephant, fearless and endowed with the ornament of tranquility.'[7] This virtuous monk's disposition and fearlessness, as much as his preaching, were responsible for Ashoka becoming a lay disciple of the Buddha. In a wonderful reply to the